‘likely whereabouts’. When his interrogation had started, Santhan had spilt the name of someone who could be helping Sivarasan—Dixon, the same LTTE cadre who had met Santhan at the engineer’s apartment on Eldams Road on 22 June. From there, Santhan had taken Dixon to Sivarasan’s hideout in Everready Colony, where the assassins were staying with Vijayan and his family. Santhan had introduced Suresh Master from the political group to Dixon and others later, a move that indicated that the entry of the political group’s head, Gundu ‘Trichy’ Santhan, was imminent. Jaffna was considering handing over Sivarasan to Trichy Santhan for further action. Suthenthiraraja alias Santhan clarified that Suresh Master was Trichy Santhan’s number two, who looked after wounded LTTE cadres undergoing treatment in LTTE hideouts across Tamil Nadu. Pottu Amman’s assurance to Sivarasan, when the latter had sounded sure he would be arrested, was taking shape. The SIT had released a photograph of Dixon in the newspapers, and the CBI’s staff had pasted flyers with Dixon’s and Sivarasan’s pictures in autorickshaws. The flyers mentioned Dixon’s role in helping Sivarasan and gang move to a hideout, underlining how crucial his arrest was to the investigation. The assassins were believed to be commuting in autorickshaws.

The manhunt for Sivarasan had by now extended beyond India. The CBI had enlisted the services of Interpol, the Narcotics Control Bureau (NCB), the Royal Canadian Mounted Police and Scotland Yard in London, seeking help in identifying some of Sivarasan’s associates who had operated from foreign soil. Interpol was concentrating on finding out more about the LTTE’s international links.

Verma claimed before Kaarthikeyan and Raju that information gathered so far on the LTTE’s contacts and activities abroad could be used to test the theory that a foreign hand might have been involved in the plot to assassinate Rajiv Gandhi, with the LTTE as a willing tool. Kaarthikeyan straightaway refused. He said that was comparatively a ‘long shot’. Closing the case would be impossible unless Sivarasan was caught and questioned. And the SIT boss was unwilling to look beyond that. Verma acknowledged